Video recording as interaction: participant observation of children's everyday life

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This article investigates methodological and analytical implications of video-based techniques for conducting participant observations with children (6–8 years of age). Video-based data are used to illustrate arguments concerning how children use different interaction strategies while being observed with a video camera. It is also argued that visual recordings constitute a source of knowledge in their own right. Hence, a strong claim is made concerning the importance of researchers reflecting upon recording procedures. The article also offers a discussion of some methodological issues that play a crucial role in video recording young children's peer interactions. The article emphasizes the need to attend to and reflect on all components of the research process, including procedures for data collection and visual analysis, as well as how the visual material is reproduced in the written text. *Qualitative Research in Psychology* 2005; **2:** 241–255

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Introduction

It is now more common than ever to use video cameras as tools for collecting empirical data for qualitative research (cf. Emmison and Smith, 2000; Pink, 2001). Moreover, visual methodologies are increasingly used within different areas of research, such as psychology, conversation analysis, ethnography, education studies and child studies. This being the case, it is important not to neglect the fact that video-based methodologies create specific ways of looking at and understanding the world. This article offers a discussion of some methodological issues that play a crucial role in

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video recording children during participant observations within the peer group. Video-based recordings will be used to illustrate some of the arguments. Most of the recordings were collected at a Swedish after-school centre (children aged 6–8).[1] Analysing children's interactions with a focus on their use of visual artefacts allows us to understand the relevance and function of vision and visualities in children's identity construction as well as their ways of negotiating the visual in the course of their everyday life. The notion of *visual culture* is used to focus on how social and cultural meanings are constructed through visuality, i.e. vision is socially and culturally constructed at the same time as the visual also constructs the social (cf. Mirzoeff, 1998; Mitchell, 2002). This article should partly be read as a contribution to the social theory of visuality.

In the article, children are treated as agents who participate in the construction of the video-recorded research material. Understanding children as social and cultural agents is in accordance with theories formulated in, among other schools of thought, the New Sociology of Childhood (e.g., Halldén, 2003; James and Prout, 1990; James *et al*., 1998; Jenks, 1996). The New Sociology of Childhood states that childhood is a social construction and that children should be understood as active in the construction of their own social lives, i.e., children's social relationships and cultures are both worthwhile and important to study in their own right. Taking children's perspectives implies questioning developmental psychology's view on childhood and child development as a progression from simplicity to complexity, i.e., from a primitive mentality to full human status as a rational adult (James and Prout, 1990; Jenks, 1996). Jenks (1996) argues that Jean Piaget's theories of children's developmental behaviours have had an 'immeasurable impact upon the everyday common-sense conceptualisation of the child' (Jenks, 1996: 29). The New Sociology of Childhood challenges this common-sense notion and argues in favour of children's agency both in peer interactions as well as on a societal level, i.e., that children are social citizens in their own right. However, it is also important not to treat children as overcompetent. To avoid this dichotomy between primitivism and rational competence, it is important to study children's actual practices (cf. Buckingham, 2000; Sparrman, 2002a; Sparrman and Aronsson, 2003).

Combining theories of agency and an ethnographic method with analysis of children's peer interactions allows us to explore how children both construct and are constructed by the fact that they are being observed with a video camera. Accordingly, the present article elaborates on and discusses the use of visual recording while conducting participant observations with young children. Thus, the aim is not to understand children's specific psychological or cognitive processes, but to keep an interactional focus. The article explores how young children use different interaction strategies in relation to the presence of a researcher with a video camera. An additional and important question addressed throughout the article involves reflecting upon what video recording implies as a visual methodology. Also emphasized are the limitations of video recording, as well as the contribution it can make that is lacking in other qualitative research methods.

It has become more common to use video recording instead of audio recording when conducting Conversation Analysis (cf. C. Goodwin, 1995, 2000; Heath, 1997). The use of video facilitates studies of visual aspects of human conduct, i.e., how

visual actions, such as nonverbal activities (e.g., gazes) or material objects intertwine with talk as resources for interaction (C. Goodwin, 1995, 2000; Heath, 1997). Video recordings are also used when conducting interactional studies of children to understand their social conduct in peer relations (cf. Corsaro, 1997; Cromdal, 2000; Evaldsson, 2003; M.H. Goodwin, 1995; Sparrman, 2002b; Sparrman and Aronsson, 2003; Thorell, 1998; for an overview of talk-in-interaction among children see Kyratzis, 2004). One issue, however, is that video recording as a method is often pursued in the absence of reflexive methodological discussions (for a critical overview of some Nordic theses, 1993–2002, see Heikkilä and Sahlström, 2003).

Observing children with video is also traditional within developmental psychology. In these settings, video observations, among other things, have been used to investigate various behaviours. In the new introduction to his book *The First Relationship* (2002), Daniel N. Stern reflects upon the new possibilities for behavioural research that emerged through the use of television and movie cameras during the 1960s. The technology allowed researchers to examine split seconds of human behaviour, i.e., the small details that make up larger behavioural patterns. Although visual techniques and methodologies are largely used in research on the motor systems of gaze control (cf. Stern, 2002), as in much other video-based research, critical and reflexive discussions are scarce.

Film cameras and still photography have long been used as research tools in the area of Visual Anthropology (Bateson and Mead, 1942; Banks, 1995; Banks and Morphy, 1997). Marcus Banks and Howard Morphy (1997) argue that video recordings today not only complement participant observations or field notes but may indeed constitute the main research data: the visual recordings constitute a source of knowledge in their own right. This makes it extremely important to reflect upon and discuss issues related to recording procedures and the use of technology during fieldwork. Matters of how data collection is conducted, technological implications as well as how visual material should be analysed must be considered.

Another important issue is ethical considerations concerning how, in this case, children may or should be visualized in research publications.

To observe and be observed

The mere thought that someone is observing you can make the most innocent act stand out as forbidden (e.g., Foucault, 1991; Mulvey, 1975/1992). We could describe the presence of a video camera during observations as a powerful and omnipresent Big Brother's eye (Orwell, 1949). The camera sees, registers and also hears what is said. Thus, the children in this article showed their consciousness of being video recorded, particularly the first time the video camera was introduced. Suddenly, discussions of home videos, being on TV programmes and surveillance cameras were items on the agenda. Also knowledge about the video recordings' potential use as evidence was displayed when children reminded each other or themselves of the presence of the camera. This was brought up when sensitive topics such as sexuality or unpopular teachers were on the agenda or when they did something they knew was forbidden. It was as if they suddenly realized that everything they said and did was being registered by a video camera and that the videotapes could

be used as evidence against them: 'Will you show this to anyone later?'

By focusing on how and when the children interacted with the video camera, it became possible to take a critical stand and reflect upon children's understanding of being video recorded. As a clarification, it should be pointed out that verbal comments on the presence of the camera were rare. For instance, when a conflict began between the children, their most common strategy was to call upon one of the teachers to deal with disagreements instead of upon me, despite the fact that I was present in the room. This was probably due to my early and firm reminders that I was not a teacher, but a researcher video recording children's activities at the centre. This approach together with the video camera helped me to become a social person different from the teachers, as I soon became 'the one with the camera'. In this way, my task was clear and my presence sanctioned.

If we were to make a continuum of children's concern about being observed by a video camera, there would be an explicit ban of the camera on one end: 'You can't film me [looks into the camera]. Film someone else' and explicit invitations and wishes to be video recorded on the other. A boy sits down next to a couple of girls. He looks into the camera and says: 'Finally, now I'm getting filmed.' Or as Kasper makes clear:

Participants: Kasper (age 7) and Anna (researcher)
Setting: After-school centre

Kasper:	When are you coming? Sure we'll =
Anna:	Am I supposed to come?
Kasper:	= going to be filmed?
Anna:	Well?
Kasper:	Later, with that camera? Sure?
Anna:	Ehm.
Kasper:	Or what is the camera for anyway?
Anna:	Okay (clears throat). You have to wait for a bit though?

Kasper's questions show how eager he is to be video recorded. Instead of refusing to be video recorded, he questions my very presence if I do not record him and his friend's activities. Other research on children in which a video camera was used has shown that children may also use the fact that they are being video recorded for their own purposes (Cromdal, 2000). Jakob Cromdal (2000) shows how two schoolgirls use the fact that he is filming them as a legitimizer to be included and stay in some other girls' game. However, it is not only verbal comments that expose children's understandings of a video camera.

Cultural meanings of a video camera

When entering the field to make video recordings at the after-school centre, my approach was to be open-minded and approving of children's curiosity about the camera. All children were allowed to look at the video camera, hold it and ask questions about how much it weighed, who owned it, etc. The purpose of this was to defuse the presence of the technology and to demystify being video recorded. When analysing sequences of such explorations, I found that the cultural understandings children associated with the video were envisioned.

One of the children's recurrent activities at the beginning of my visit to the centre was imitating pop groups; a special focus was on the Spice Girls. Groups of children would close themselves into small rooms to practise dancing and mimicry before inviting an audience to watch. On one occasion, I was invited to watch a performance and the children's awareness and concentration on the camera made me slightly uncomfortable. While dancing and miming, they walked up and looked straight into the camera in sophisticated and alluring ways. It felt to me as if the presence of the camera

was governing the situation. Not until later, when analysing these specific video sequences, did it become clear that the camera had been used for specific purposes, i.e., to make the performance look like a music video. While dancing and miming in front of the camera, the children exposed their knowledge of how video cameras are approached when making music videos. Using this strategy, they presumed the presence of an audience at the other end of the camera shot while disregarding the audience present in the room. However, it may be that the use of the camera was also a strategy for making sense of its presence during the performance.

An additional way children approached and explored the camera was to pretend to be news reporters or anchormen on television by pretending to hold a microphone, looking into the camera and verbally reporting using a TV-news voice.

Two girls used picture books to pretend to produce a Swedish children's programme. The activity was clearly inspired by a programme in which picture books are read aloud by an adult. Every now and then the storyteller would turn the book around towards the camera to show the pictures.

These activities emerged from the girl's curiosity about the camera and more specifically the camera display (Image 1). I was sitting on a big sofa, video recording activities in a room at a distance. Initially, the two girls quietly climbed up and sat next to me to look into the display window.

After a while, the camera was embedded in a game introduced when one of the girls picked up a picture book. I showed no disapproval of the activity, as I had decided to let the children explore the technology. I held the camera while the girls took turns reading aloud from different picture books (Image 2). Every now and then a picture from the book was shown (Image 3). Moreover, reading was replaced by the girls' own story lines, which they used to parody and make ironic remarks about the storyteller genre.

The examples give a picture of how interactions with the observational technique also generated knowledge about the cultural meanings children attach to the video technique. There is a slight difference between the examples. In the Spice Girls example, the girls used the fact that they were filmed as a resource in the activity. They were not exploring the technique

Image 1 Video camera with the foldout display. Sony Handicam Vision CCD-TRV65EPAL.

Image 2 Story-teller on 'television'.

per se, but embedding it in the game. In the story-telling example, on the other hand, it is the technique itself that generates the activity. The design of the display looks like a miniature TV screen and inspires them to take turns creating and watching a TV programme. The same is true of the news-reporter game. However, all three activities highlight children's knowledge of visual and verbal strategies used, as well as cultural values, in producing TV news, music videos and story-telling programmes.

Who observes whom?

It is almost impossible for an adult to conduct research among children as a full and participating member (Adler and Adler, 1994), i.e., as a participant in a group under equal conditions. The fact that the researcher is an adult makes the relationship to the young child unequal; age, power over decision-making and responsibility are among the factors contributing to this inequality. Adding a video camera to the

Image 3 Showing the picture to the audience.

situation may additionally complicate the power relations. Still you can be just as intriguing as an observer without a camera, depending on how you enter a room or on whether you scribble in a book while participating in an activity (Adler and Adler, 1994). In his study of conversational codeswitching among bilingual children in Sweden (age 6–10 years), Cromdal (2000) initially used both a tape recorder and a video camera to collect his research material. Cromdal's reflection is that the tape recorder was more scrutinized by the children than was the video camera. One reason for this may be that, in today's western world, children are more used to being video recorded than are earlier generations, because home video cameras command a huge market and one important target group is families. Audio recordings, on the other hand, are seldom part of the child's domestic experience. Hence, the video camera is not merely intriguing – it may also help to establish for the researcher a status different from other adults in the child's environment (e.g., teachers) as, say, a filmmaker, or the one interested in how children play, or any other social identity that may be ascribed to the observer.

Sometimes the children negotiated about what should and should not be allowed to be video recorded. For instance, one group of girls (age 8) were writing and drawing secret letters to one another. When a letter was ready it was sent via a mailbox constructed by the girls. All the girls protected their letters while they were writing and drawing. They leaned over the table using their arms, boxes and loose-leaf binders as shields to construct secret spaces. In the middle of this letter project two girls, Ronja and Elise, suddenly addressed me, bursting out: 'You can't film mine' cause it's a bit yucky' (Ronja), 'Not mine EITHER' (Elise).

I answered the girls by saying that, 'yucky' or not, it was fine with me and that no one except me would watch the video recordings. It turned out the girls were not worried on my account or about the video recording as such. They rather found it embarrassing for the person who was going to receive the letters that someone else had seen the 'yucky' content. I asked what they meant by 'yucky' and what in the letters was offensive. So that no one else could overhear, one at a time, they whispered an explanation in my ear. After this, it was somehow all right to continue recording.

With this example as a point of departure and with further investigation of more video recordings, it became obvious that the children sometimes differentiated between the video camera and me as a person. When Elise had finished her letter and mailed it, a third girl in the room, Stina, asked to see the letter. Elise showed the letter quickly to Stina – there was a drawing of two people kissing – while telling her not to read the text. Without a word, Elise then turned towards the video camera and held the letter up in front of it for a long time – though not towards me. I was actually behind the camera, holding it in my hand, but I did not look in the lens as the camera had a fold-out display on the side (cf. Image 1). I was not hidden behind the camera, but holding it at waist level.

In this way, the camera was 'the only one' who could see both the exposed picture and read the text. It was as if the camera had become an intimate friend to Elise. She whispered her secret to me, but without a word showed the whole letter to the camera. It is true that the camera can register, preserve and listen, but it cannot speak and therefore it cannot immediately give away the 'yucky' content of the letter.

Showing it to me would have entailed a risk of my expressing liking or disliking, both verbally and through gestures. My argument is that it is not merely by coincidence that Elise held up her letter towards the camera lens instead of towards me. In this way, she was making a distinction between the camera – an object – and me as a social person.

Two boys found another way of informing the camera and me. Using pretend video cameras made out of plastic toy bricks, they approached me in action while I was recording. They stopped in front of me with their own cameras and for a few seconds we were filming each other (Image 4).

When the boys turned around to film some of their friends, my camera was still recording them. While analysing this video sequence, my own gaze returned to myself, creating a double consciousness (Du Bois, 1998/1903) of looking at myself through the eyes of the observing children. It made me aware of my visibility in at least two ways: both as an observer with a video camera and as an adult interacting in children's activities. The boys' game illustrated in a very concrete way how both being observed and being an observer can be perceived.

Image 4 Boy video recording with a toy camera.

Other situations in which the distinction between the camera and me was clear-cut were, for example, when the children commented on changes in my appearance. Why did I wear specs one day but not the other? I was also given attention when children needed help with, for example, their spelling.

Another way in which the children reacted to the presence of the camera eye was to provoke, investigate or make fun of the after-school centre's regulations by doing forbidden or outrageous things. This could involve 'flipping the camera the bird' or, as two girls did (age 8): first making sure I was video recording, they leaned towards each other and kissed rapidly twice on the mouth, followed by a big laugh.

Some children also commented on forgetting that they were being video recorded: 'Guys have you noticed that she is, the one who films us now?', or not caring about it even though they were doing something forbidden. Two boys (age 7) sat around a table rubbing pencils against the table edge making marks both on the pencils and the table; Boy 1: 'They're film [hiccups] filming you!', Boy 2: 'Well who cares [looks into the camera]'. While this conversation may show how the presence of the camera and myself are being tested – as to how far they can go without interference – the boys show that they have accepted me as someone who does not primarily belong to the institution.

Taken together, the activities presented under this heading involve a displacement of focus in relation to the research issue, because the gazes are directed towards the video camera or me as a researcher rather than on the children's own activities. However, the interactions contribute important

knowledge about how children may perceive and relate to the fact that they are being observed with a video camera and a present observer. They also shed light on the social roles a researcher may be ascribed.

Practical issues conducting participant observations with children and a video camera

Video recording is not, as mentioned in the introduction, a coherent visual methodology. To say that you are doing visual ethnography or participant observations with a video camera mean different things to different researchers. Some who do research on talk-in-interaction argue in favour of rigging a video camera up on a tripod and leaving the room (cf. Eriksson, 2002; Tholander, 2002). In these situations, the researchers are striving to create as little disturbance as possible. You could also choose to be present during recordings, intending not to intervene. In these cases, you could be present to support equipment, for example to move the camera from one side of the room to the other during a session (Sparrman and Eriksson, 2005). Yet another advancement could be to leave the tripod behind and carry the camera around. In this way, you – the researcher – are free to be and interact with the children while they are invited to interact with you as well as the technology (e.g., Cromdal, 2000; Sparrman, 2002b). When collecting the data for this article, no tripod was used.

Camera angle and visual evidence

A video camera offers a number of advantages, but it also has limitations. To begin with, a camera lens is designed in a way that makes it impossible to take in all aspects of a course of events. It may also be difficult to capture all children scattered around a table. Even though they are engaged in the same activity, only a few of them can be recorded at the same time. Accordingly, some processes may not be visible in the recorded material, an aspect that can be complemented to a certain degree through the use of a camera with display (cf. Image 1), written field notes or by spending a length of time in the field.

Many external preconditions influence how choices are made and how camera angles are chosen. The design and spatial organization of rooms constitute one such restricting factor. Thus, it is not always possible to choose what to record or not without interrupting ongoing activities. The researcher plans the video recordings in interaction with the surroundings, and s/he must also adjust to the frameworks, in this case, of children's peer interactions.

When analysing the collected video recordings, it is important to reflect upon, for example, recording conventions and procedures for analysing visual material. In the area of Visual Anthropology, discussions on these issues have taken place in relation to ethnographic documentary film (Ruby, 1995). In contrast to such films, however the present video material will never result in an edited film. Therefore aspects such as composition, camera angle, light conditions and form matter less, both during recording and during analysis. It is important to remember that video recordings made for research do not primarily have an aesthetic purpose and are never intended to please an audience, but instead to help in answering research questions.

When conducting the fieldwork addressed here, one important principle was to video record all children at least once,

regardless of the nature of the activity at hand; this was done to prevent enviousness and conflicts. Because one of the aims of the after-school centre study was to examine children's peer group interactions, the ambition was to ensure that recordings were not made from a first person perspective (cf. Monaco, 2000). When recording, the camera display (cf. Image 1) became crucial, as the display allowed the researcher to have a general view and attend to the atmosphere of a situation at the same time. Hence, choosing an over-the-shoulder camera angle focused on one specific child – first-person perspective – may, depending on the research issue, become problematic during the analytic work.

In the area of psychoanalytic film research, one important issue has been to discuss whom you as a viewer identify with, both from a visual and narrative point of view when watching a Hollywood film (Mulvey, 1975/1992; Stacey, 1994). The Hollywood movie industry has trained spectators to perceive an over-the-shoulder shot as a first-person perspective. Thus, it is a common conception that viewers identify with the actor exposed in this way and see the action in the film through that character's point of view. As a researcher, it may be important to reflect upon common cultural values connected to accounts of film production and upon methods for analysing images when conducting visual research. Accordingly, even at the outset of data collection, it is important to be aware of how camera shots are established and reflect upon the social and cultural construction of vision (cf. Mirzoeff, 1988 and Mitchell, 2002). The researcher constructs a specific way of seeing by and through the video camera; thereby the recorded material *per se* also becomes a social and cultural statement. Seeing and looking are always acts of interpretation.

The above arguments are related to ideas about how video recordings are approached and evaluated as research data. Photography, a genre related to video recordings and film, has a long and immutable aura of truth-value connected to it. While photography has a long history of penetrating the relativity and validity of photographs as evidence (cf. Sontag, 1979), photographic truth is rarely discussed as an important aspect in relation to video recordings used in research projects (for a good example see Pink, 2001). As Victor Burgin (1997) states, a formal device, such as an image, is always producing an ideological content. There is no a political photographing, because all of us are part of political situations. This notion applies to researchers as well. My claim is that the notion that photographs are not products of observed natural truths can be applied to video recordings made as part of a research process.

Children on display – ethical considerations

Visual methods are rarely only visual; they also depend on other cultural expressions such as words, text, technology, the researcher's role and the identities of informants (Pink, 2001). One problem associated with turning images of, in this case children, into text is related to the presentation and publication of research results. Awareness of how children are visualized in research is of utmost importance. It is also important to consider for what purposes and why informants should be put on display in research. It is easy to be seduced by all the possibilities offered by modern

technology. There are, however, some negotiable representation strategies available.

Image 5 Blurred face.

Image 6 Contour drawing prepared in Photoshop.

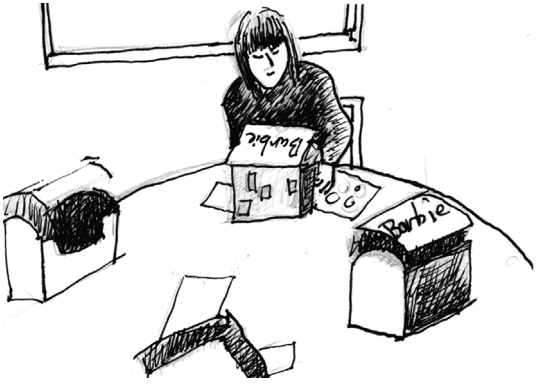

Image 7 Pencil drawing from video still, by Robert Svensson.

Image 8 Illustration, Happy Meal box from McDonald's.

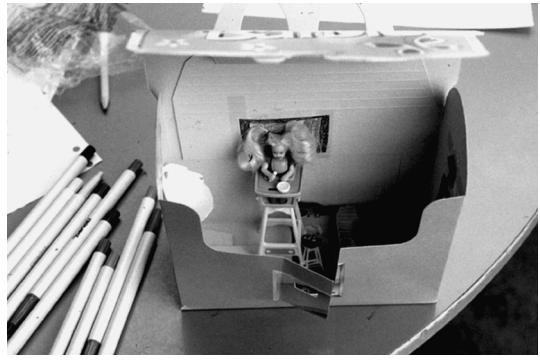

Image 9 Illustration, interior of Happy Meal box.

One strategy is to freeze a video image of a child and lift it out of its actual context. A strategy to protect the identity is to blur the face, as is done in Image 5. Depending on the research question, this solution may be complicated, as it is a common way to present criminals in newspapers or in TV programmes. Blurring the face brings about easy associations with these specific image genres. What is more, blurring the face accords poorly with the present approach of understanding children as agents. One way to get around these problems is to produce new images based on original video images. In this way, it is still possible

to show important situations from the research field while protecting children's identities, as in the contour Image 6 made in Photoshop of Image 5 and in Image 7, which is a drawing of the same situation.

A practical reason for not using frozen video images in publications may also be the issue of quality. Because the strategy is usually to keep video recording regardless of light conditions, etc., the quality of the recordings may sometimes be poor. In such cases, it is possible to illustrate an activity with a photograph and to complement video recordings with photographs. An illustrative photograph can exclude the child while still showing what the child is focusing on in the activity. Both Image 8 and Image 9 show details from Image 5. The photographics becomes illustrations of an activity, images elucidating another image. Another strategy may be to take photographs of different artefacts, parallel to video recording children, in order to show children's products while protecting their identities. The overall goal must be to maintain a critical approach to video-recorded material: from data collection to analysis to publication.

Video recordings as interaction – concluding remarks

The interactionist approach promoted here and used to understand how young children (6–8 years) make sense of being video recorded has enabled us to see what aspects children focus on. Children would seem to have a mixture of interests, ranging from the technology to challenging or teasing the camera and using it for their own purposes to gaining access to other peers. The researcher was both invited to video record some things and prohibited from recording others; she was also explored as a social person, as the camera was as an object. The article shows that video recording as a methodology builds on give and take, and that even though the researcher is holding the camera, the recordings are generated through interaction between her/him and the informants.

The empirical examples also show that there is no such thing as objective technology. Children's explorations of the technology, their interactions with the researcher holding the video camera as well as their verbal comments about the presence of the camera make it clear that cultural ideas and values are embedded in the interaction with the technology. Accordingly, the recorded research material is a product constituted by face-to-face interaction between children and researcher as well as by social and cultural processes. However, co-construction of the data does not lessen their value, as long as they are not approached as truth claims but as a result of interactive situated activities.

It has been argued that visual recordings constitute a source of knowledge in their own right and that this makes it extremely important to reflect upon recording procedures. Another argument is that the technology *per se* is part of the kind of data obtained as well as part of how researchers construct the data. Use of visual methodologies often implies that the researcher both collects and analyses the video material by her/himself. I wish to stress the great importance of being aware of how video recordings are made and of what guidelines are used when analysing the visual material. As has been pointed out, common cultural conventions of visuality are something every researcher brings to the analytic work behind the desk. Because there is still a relative scarcity in the literature of

discussions on the photographic truth of video recordings, this is a subject in need of further exploration. An image is never just an image. Images are always situated in time, space and cultural/historic conditions. This aesthetic of images goes beyond ideas that images come with precise inherent cultural values. However, this is often still the commonsense understanding of images; they are treated as powerful, seductive and as documented reality. This everyday understanding of images is easily put into practice when collecting and analysing visual research material. The aim of this article has been to move beyond this everyday common sense.

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Note

1. The study generated 90 hours of video recordings during a period of five months of participant observations with a video camera. The ethnographic recordings were used to transcribe interaction on a micro-level to investigate children's relations to visual culture. Overall findings showed that children constantly negotiated visuality. It was shown, for example, that children exploited visuality as a tool in gender identity work, friendship alliances and power relations. However, at the same time, the visuality of the social (architecture, images on cloths, drawing repertoires etc.) also restricted children's actions. Among other things the study contributed to an understanding of visuality as both a resource and a restriction in children's lives.

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